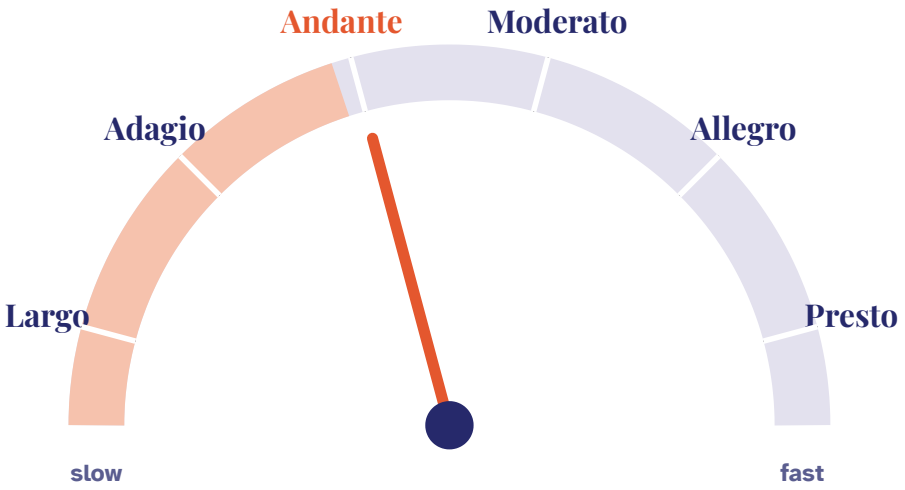
PART III · EXPRESSION · 3

Speed words

How fast is the beat? A word at the top of the music tells you, usually in Italian, and often a number too. Other words inside the music ask you to slow down, speed up, or wait.

THE SECRET

The word at the top sets the speed; rit. brakes gently, a tempo drives off again.



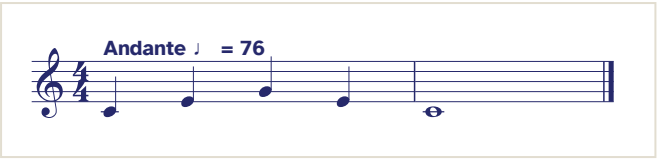
Andante: the speed of walking

WORD	MEANING	ABOUT (BEATS A MINUTE)
Largo	very slow and broad	40–60
Lento	slow	45–60
Adagio	slow, at ease	60–76
Andante	at a walking pace	76–108
Moderato	at a moderate speed	108–120
Allegretto	fairly fast, a little slower than Allegro	112–120
Allegro	fast and lively	120–156
Vivace	lively and brisk	156–176
Presto	very fast	168–200

The numbers are a rough guide: the music and the room decide the rest.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 3 · CONTINUED

The metronome mark



♩ = 76 means 76 crotchet beats in one minute. Set a metronome to 76: each click is one beat. The word tells you the character; the number pins down the speed.

EXAMPLE 1

How fast is ♩ = 60?

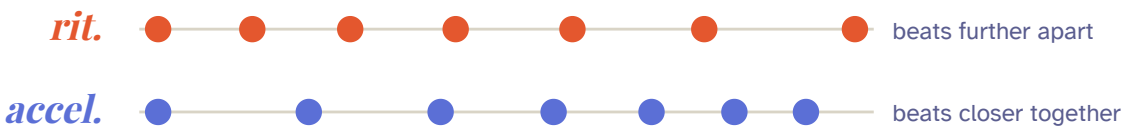


1. **60 beats** in one minute.
2. **How many seconds** are there in a minute?
3. **So one beat** lasts how long?

One beat every **second**: tick, tick, like a clock.
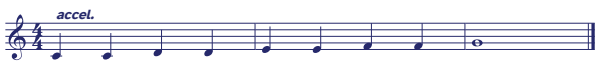
Changing speed

WORD OR SIGN	WHAT YOU DO
rit. (ritardando), *rall.* (rallentando)	gradually slower
accel. (accelerando)	gradually faster
a tempo	back to the speed before
𝄐 fermata (pause)	hold longer than written, then go on
poco a poco	little by little
molto · *poco* · *più* · *meno*	very · a little · more · less (*più mosso*: faster; *meno mosso*: slower)
rubato	time borrowed and paid back (p. 69) *Extra*





rit.: slow down into the end, then wait on the fermata.
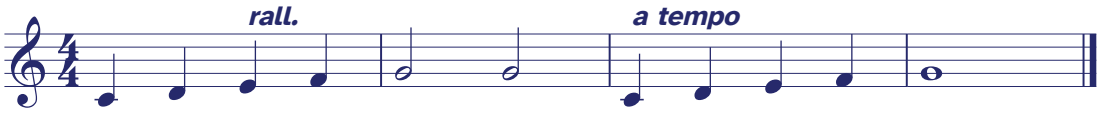


accel.: speed up, little by little, to the end.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Where does it slow down, and where does it come back?

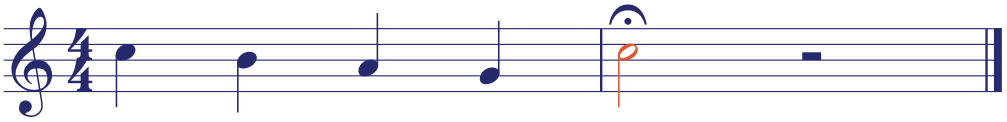


1. **Find rall.** Which notes does it slow?
2. **Find a tempo.**
3. **What speed** does a tempo mean?

Bar 1 slows into the two Gs; at **a tempo** (bar 3) the first speed comes straight back.

EXAMPLE 3

How long do you hold the fermata?
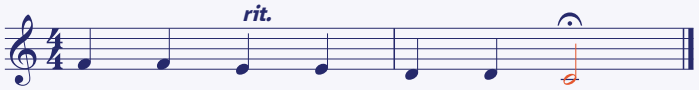


1. **The minim** is worth how many beats?
2. **The fermata** asks for more. How much?
3. **Then what?**

Longer than 2 beats: hold until it **feels finished**, often half as long again or more, then go on.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



Players often slow down into the last “are”: a **rit.**, then a fermata on the final C. The ending feels like coming home.

Try it. Sing the last line twice: once in time, once with a rit.

THINK OF IT A rit. is a car braking gently at the lights; a tempo is driving off again at the same speed as before.

TRAP

- × Taking Andante as slow: it is a walking pace.
- × Slowing down all at once at rit.: slow little by little.
- × Forgetting a tempo: after a rit., the first speed comes back exactly.

SEE ALSO

Pulse and tempo p. 50 · Rubato p. 69

PRACTISE IT

Online: Metronome